WeChat, Baidu or Tencent. More important, the spheres aren't mirror images of each other. It is not that the Chinese and Americans develop local versions of the same apps. Baidu isn't the Chinese Google. Alibaba isn't the Chinese Amazon. They have different goals, different digital architectures and different impacts on people's lives.[26] These differences influence much of the world, since most countries rely on Chinese and American software rather than on local technology.

Each sphere also uses different hardware like smartphones and computers. The United States pressures its allies and clients to avoid Chinese hardware, such as Huawei's 5G infrastructure.[27] The Trump administration blocked an attempt by the Singaporean corporation Broadcom to buy the leading American producer of computer chips, Qualcomm. They feared foreigners might insert back doors into the chips or would prevent the US government from inserting its own back doors there.[28] In 2022, the Biden administration placed strict limits on trade in high-performance computing chips necessary for the development of AI. US companies were forbidden to export such chips to China, or to provide China with the means to manufacture or repair them. The restrictions have subsequently been tightened further, and the ban was expanded to include other nations such as Russia and Iran.[29] While in the short term this hampers China in the AI race, in the long term it will push China to develop a completely separate digital sphere that will be distinct from the American digital sphere even in its smallest building blocks.[30]

The two digital spheres may drift further and further apart. Chinese software would talk only with Chinese hardware and Chinese infrastructure, and the same would happen on the other side of the Silicon Curtain. Since digital code influences human behaviour, and human behaviour in turn shapes digital code, the two sides may well be moving along different trajectories that will make them more and more different not just in their technology but in their cultural values, social norms and political structures. After generations of convergence, humanity could find itself at a crucial point of divergence.[31] For centuries, new information technologies fuelled the process of globalisation and brought people all over the world into closer contact. Paradoxically, information technology today is so powerful it can potentially split humanity by enclosing different people in separate information cocoons, ending the idea of a single shared human reality.